Today's goal • 0/3 items
Complete 3 items today to stay at a good pace!

Module 1
Introduction to What Is Contemporary Art?

Module 2
Media from Television to the Internet

Module 3
Territories & Transit

Module 4
Materials & Making

Module 5
Agency

Visibility

- Introduction to Module 5 — Reading • 10 min
- Pope.L's New York crawls — Reading • 10 min
- In New York City with Pope.L | Direct action — Video • 4 min
- Two artists consider Catherine Opie, Dyke, 1993 — Video • 2 min
- Tania Bruguera on Untitled (Havana, 2000), 2000 — Video • 4 min
- Luis Camnitzer on Memorial, 2009 — Video • 2 min
- **Yara Said on the Refugee Flag, 2016** — Reading • 10 min
- Firelei Báez on For Amérthyste and Athénaïre (Exiled Muses Beyond Jean Luc Nancy's Canon), Anacaonas, 2018 — Reading • 10 min

Voice

- Who speaks? — Reading • 10 min
- Nick Cave on Soundsuit, 2011 — Video • 2 min
- Lawrence Abu Hamdan, Conflicted Phonemes, 2012 — Reading • 10 min
- P Staff on Weed Killer, 2017 — Reading • 10 min

Action

- Taking action — Reading • 10 min
- Lorraine O'Grady on Mlle Bourgeoise Noire, 1980-83/2009 — Video • 2 min
- Xiao Lu on Dialogue, 1989 — Video • 2 min
- Ralph Borland, Suited for Subversion (Prototype), 2002 — Video • 1 min
- Defining and blurring identities through performance — Reading • 10 min

Review & Respond

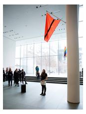
- Memory Check — Practice Assignment
- Reflect on Agency in Module 5 — Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Readings & Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Power

Yara Said on the Refugee Flag, 2016

1:12 / 6:31

At the opening ceremonies of the 2016 Olympics in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, a group of refugee athletes carried for the first time a flag symbolizing their displacement, as well as their unity as a part of a worldwide "Refugee Nation." Syrian artist Yara Said designed their Refugee Flag. A refugee herself, she drew inspiration from life vests and her own experience of crossing the Mediterranean from Turkey to Greece to escape her country's civil war. Instructor Arièle Dionne-Krosnick corresponded with Said about Refugee Flag.



Refugee Nation, Yara Said. *Refugee Flag*. 2016. Nylon, 44 × 58" (111.8 × 147.3 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of Refugee Nation. Installation view, The Museum of Modern Art, New York, January 2018. Digital Image © 2019 MoMA, NY. Photo: Manuel Martagon

Arièle Dionne-Krosnick, MoMA: How did Refugee Nation approach you and ask you to design the Refugee Flag?

Yara Said: I was contacted by Refugee Nation in June 2016, when I was doing a two-year residency at a studio in Amsterdam, the Netherlands. I received an email asking me to design a flag for a refugee team that was going to the Olympics in Rio de Janeiro in August. I had one month to design it and complete freedom to choose the design. They [the refugee team] had formed a 17-day temporary nation, and this nation would have an anthem that was composed by Istanbul-based composer Moutaz Arian. The [nation's] "residents" were ten athletes from The Republic of Congo, South Sudan, Syria, and Ethiopia. A flag would bring all of these athletes together who could not be represented by their own countries due to the political situations.

What were you trying to communicate with your design choices for the flag?

Before agreeing to design the flag, I was really curious to understand more about the people behind the gesture, therefore I asked for information about the athletes and the context of their participation. My mind was blown, and I was extremely touched by the amount of strength and resistance these athletes showed. It made me feel less alone in my own struggle as a recently relocated artist in a new country and reconfirmed my astonishment with human survival. These athletes were running, swimming, and fighting for their beliefs with a different agency, a different form of activism.

From that point, I based the design without any hesitation on my own experience of crossing the sea from Turkey to Greece in a life vest, which turned out (like many others) to be poorly made. After moving to Amsterdam I became familiar with the life vest "graveyard" located in Greece—a dump that contains thousands of life vests. These life vests were worn by thousands of humans—mothers, daughters, students, workers, doctors, and children—who all shared one experience, which is crossing from danger to safety. Usually, a life vest is supposed to protect people, but in this case it was harming them. It was a danger sign and an indication of where the Western and Eastern political agendas stand in our age. The colors of the flag are black and orange. The flag is supposed to form a life vest when wrapped around the body, offering the audience a brief moment of association.



Refugee Flag design. Courtesy Yara Said

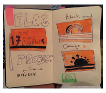
What did you learn when you researched flag design?

On the practical side of the design process I started researching what a flag should look like and what it means: a flag is a signal, a sign of life, a human presence.

I also made sure that it would follow three rules:

- A maximum of three colors
- Minimalism in design
- It should look like a six-year-old could also draw it or make it (which was extremely fun because I am quite playful with my artworks)

From there I started sketching. The personal relationship I had with the situation made the decision-making process quite easy. I was making an artwork that, like all of my other works, represented me and my experiences.



Original sketch book of the refugee nation flag thought process. Courtesy Yara Said

What did it mean to you to see the Refugee Flag carried by refugee athletes at the 2016 Rio Olympics?

It was a very beautiful moment. I remember crying very hard when I watched one video in which athlete Popole Misenga talked about how much it meant to him to be at the Olympics. He was hoping that if his family saw him on television (he was separated from his family at a very young age), they would recognize him and contact him. It meant the world to me to be able to offer a very small gesture to these amazing people. I was speechless.

You've said that the beginning of the war in Syria sparked your artistic career. How so?

I became an artist during the war. I started painting when I was three years old and had official artistic training when I was 16. Since then, I have never stopped making art. The presence of war shaped my artistic practice daily. It was something I couldn't run away from at that time, so I tried to fight back through painting and making. I still do that in different ways. I hope for the emergence of a new kind of activism, which I believe is already happening, that will create space to understand both the oppressed and the oppressor without judgments or expectations. And I want to be a part of it. :)



Courtesy Yara Said

Do you see your role as an artist intersecting with politics or activism?

In one of her interviews Nina Simone talks about the duty of the artist, and I think I can transmit my own thoughts through her words:

"An artist's duty, as far as I'm concerned, is to reflect the times. I think that is true of painters, sculptors, poets, musicians. As far as I'm concerned, it's their choice, but I CHOOSE to reflect the times and situations in which I find myself. That, to me, is my duty. And at this crucial time in our lives, when everything is so desperate, when every day is a matter of survival, I don't think you can help but be involved. Young people, black and white, know this. That's why they're so involved in politics. We will shape and mold this country or it will not be molded and shaped at all anymore. So I don't think you have a choice. How can you be an artist and NOT reflect the times? That to me is the definition of an artist."

Mark as completed

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